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Vol. 31 No. 2

TOMORROW'S CHILD

**Embracing
Change**

**How Schools Build a
Sense of Community**

**A Determined
Mom**





TOMORROW'S CHILD

The International Magazine for Montessori Families

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Montessori 101: What Every Parent Needs to Know

This 80-page full-color publication is a wonderful resource for anyone seeking to de-mystify Montessori. It addresses topics such as the history and philosophy of Montessori; offers a guided tour of the Montessori classroom; and serves as an illustrated guide to dozens of wonderful Montessori materials. This mini-encyclopedia of Montessori is newly redesigned and contains new sections on Infant/Toddler and Montessori Secondary programs. It is a must-have resource for anyone interested in Montessori, and one that parents will surely refer to throughout their child's Montessori experience.



ORDER NOW ONLINE
tinyurl.com/the-new-101

Inside the Issue

- 
- A young boy and girl are running through tall grass at sunset. The boy is in the foreground, wearing a dark long-sleeved shirt and jeans, with one foot lifted. The girl is behind him, wearing a light blue sweatshirt with a heart design and jeans. The background is a soft-focus field of tall grass with trees in the distance, all bathed in the warm, golden light of the setting sun.
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“Montessori schools tend to be vibrant communities.”

— HOW TO BUILD COMMUNITY, PG.8



The Parenting Puzzle

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Dear Parents and Caregivers,

Yes! It's spring and our days are getting longer, new life is everywhere, and we can open our homes and lives to a breath of fresh air. This is our last issue of *Tomorrow's Child* for the 2023-2024 school year. All the surveys, focus groups, and analysis have paid off thanks to you and your school leaders. Look how far we've come!



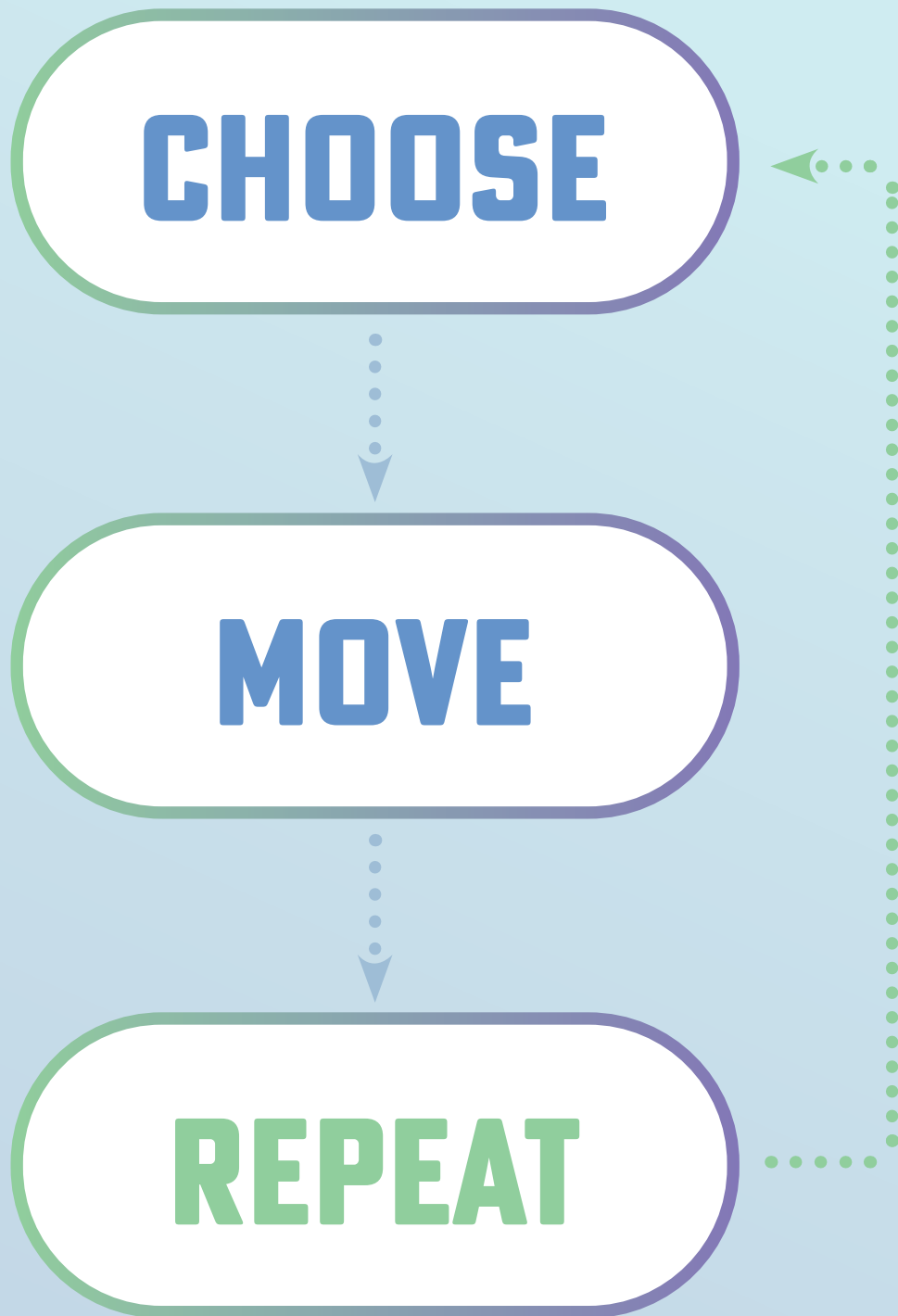
- The Montessori App makes accessing trusted resources and information easier for you.
- **Wit & Wisdom**, our monthly evening discussions with special guests, have allowed us to get to know some of you on a deeper and more personal level than ever before.
- Our new platform for the Montessori Family Life Webinars has given us opportunities to interact and connect more easily.
- The new design for *Tomorrow's Child* is filled with articles and lots of photos for every level. Each issue is meant to have something for everyone.
- Regular postings on Facebook and Instagram give you information on upcoming events and inspiring parenting tips.
- The Montessori Foundation has made *The Parenting Puzzle: 'Peacing' It All Together* available and free to schools that are members of the Montessori Family Alliance. Schools are encouraged to offer this Montessori parenting course to their families. *The Parenting Puzzle* was specifically designed to help families use Montessori principles and strategies at home to cultivate cooperation, collaboration, and calm.
- The Montessori Family Life Team has invited exciting new guests and trusted regulars who are experts in parenting practices, child and adolescent development, Montessori philosophy and pedagogy, to have conversations with you every week.

And there's more to come. We plan to continue sending school leaders a monthly newsletter to pass along to you. The newsletter highlights each *Tomorrow's Child* issue and current webinars. It also lets you see past articles, book reviews and webinars - all intended to enhance your Montessori Family Life experience and resources.

As we look forward to the 2024-2025 school year, I am reminded of a song that an old friend, Sanford Jones, wrote called "At the Beginning Is a Good Place to Be." Let us move forward with faith, trust, and hope in our children and families.

Lorna McGrath

MFA Program Director, lornamcgrath@montessori.org



**THESE THREE WORDS CAN GUIDE YOUR CHOICES
AS A PARENT OF A YOUNG CHILD.**

by Sarah Moudry



You make choices based on what you believe to be best for your child and family. These choices may be based on emotion, assumptions, or exasperation. I encourage you to consider making your decisions based on a system you know can work.

When you can create a system for yourself in your decision making for your children, you may find that you have better, less-stressful outcomes and more confidence as a parent.

Although all situations and families are different, many of the choices you make as a parent in a day can go back to these three words: Choose. Move. Repeat.

These are the three freedoms that Dr. Maria Montessori provided for in her first classroom and are still part of every authentic Montessori environment (whether home or school).

The freedom to **choose**.
The freedom to **move**.
And the freedom to **repeat**.

Within a classroom this may seem easy, but what does this mean as a parent?

I recommend that as a parent, when faced with making a decision about *What's for dinner? Do we go to the park or on a walk?* or *Will you wear a blue or green hat?* you come back to these three freedoms.

Ask yourself: *How can I offer my child choice in this situation?*

For example, if it is dinner, can he choose between carrots or green beans?

Then ask, *How can my child have the freedom to move in this situation?*

You can offer your child freedom of movement with dinner is by inviting them to help set the table or wash the carrots?

Whenever you incorporate movement into a task, you help children connect and learn. Children need to move to learn and can get very frustrated when expected to be still.

The next question you can ask is: *What part of this can we repeat?*

Well, when it comes to dinner, I suggest just one dinner (Ha!). You can think about what are the repetitions within the dinner? When setting the table, how many place settings are needed? When washing the carrots, how many carrots need to be washed? Then how can this become a daily activity? Can you repeat this multiple times a week? Can your child come to count on this as a predictable routine?

Choose, move, repeat. These three words can be a system and checklist for parents while bringing consistency, predictability, and routine to your days. They are the three words that can create harmony in your busy family life. ■



Sarah Moudry (@sarahmoudry) is an education innovator whose work is focused on creating education environments and experiences that inspire growth and joy. Her work is rooted in Montessori philosophy and paired with her extensive experience as a designer.

Recently, her projects included the founding of StudioJune (@thestudiojune), a Montessori parent and child education center, and Family Friendly Home (@familyfriendlyhome), an interior design company that creates inspirational home and school interiors.

Sarah is the author of books and online courses that help parents, childcare professionals, and grandparents to incorporate Montessori practice into their lives. She has an M.Ed in Montessori education, a B.S. in environment and design, AMI Montessori certification for birth to six years, and is an Associate Member of ASID.



How to Build Community

by Tim Seldin, President, The Montessori Foundation

Life has changed for many families over the years, and today it is more important than ever for schools and families to work together to create a nurturing community that supports parents, teachers, and children. Schools can be much more than where children learn basic skills; they can become communities where people feel safe, connected, and welcomed.

In most Montessori schools, this is already the case. Their byline could be similar to this line from Yeats: “There are no strangers here. Only friends you have yet to meet.”

Montessori parents often describe their children's schools as the center of their friendship circles.

Here are some of the many ways that great Montessori schools create community and partnership with their families, faculty, and staff.

Perhaps your child's school already does many of them. If not, perhaps now is the time to gently and positively see if you can interest the school's leadership, teachers, and other families into taking a first step.

- People smile at everyone they meet and take pains to make them feel welcome. They carefully introduce new families and staff members into the school community.



- Teachers and staff greet people as they arrive to drop off and pick up their children.
- The school encourages the entire community to get to know one another.
- School leaders and teachers make it easy for parents and students to meet with them.
- Coffee and Conversation: At many schools, families are invited to gather once a month, often right after drop off, in a central area to drink coffee while engaging in lively discussions. This not only strengthens bonds among parents but also offers a relaxed setting for informal interactions with school leaders.
- Parents are encouraged to observe classrooms in action. This can be particularly enlightening for those new to

Montessori, offering a window into their children's daily learning environment. Of course, this requires careful scheduling between parents and classroom teachers.

- They respond to any family crisis with warmth and caring. They call, visit, send cards, and lend a helping hand.
- They encourage parents to volunteer in the classrooms and on committees. They do everything possible to ensure that they have a positive experience.
- They keep volunteer assignments short to allow them to get a sense of completion.
- They avoid long boring meetings, politics, or wrangling.
- The school helps parents feel confident that their children are getting a first-class education.
- The school always has name tags at parent gatherings.
- They hold at least two "Student Demonstration" events a year: a daytime or evening where children get to bring one or two people to school as their guests. The children teach their parents or friends how to do what they do in class.
- Some schools organize a once-a-month social for all their Infant-Toddler families on Saturday afternoons. They provide an appropriate activity, such as art, music, or a sensory experience that can easily be recreated at home. Some schools hold a variation on this with "Parent-and-Me" session held at school.
- They create a tuition-funded financial-aid program with a goal that no child will have to leave school because of financial problems. They ensure that their financial-aid process is warm, friendly, and strictly confidential.
- Many Montessori schools coordinate a Parent Ambassadors program. Parent Ambassadors are a group of

dedicated parents who play a crucial role in facilitating communication between the school and families. They use email and telephone/messaging chains, enabling them to efficiently remind families of upcoming events, answer queries, and recruit volunteers for various school activities. They also welcome new families into the school community.



a theater party, a potluck dinner, or a family camp-out on the school grounds.

- Many Montessori schools hold monthly Community Meetings where parents, teachers, administrators, and interested students are invited to meet to explore issues of common interest in an open forum. Community Meetings often offer feedback and advice to the school's leadership and Board. Parents and teachers who participate tend to gain a much deeper understanding of the school's mission, strengths, and the issues that challenge it. Many appreciate the opportunity to have a voice in the life of the school.
- At a Community Meeting or other event, someone will propose a toast to the school. People share memories and stories.
- Many schools open and close the school year with special ceremonies.
- They hold special social events for the community. A few examples might include a picnic, an old-fashioned square dance, a fall festival, a winter fest, a spring picnic, a theater party, a potluck dinner, or a family camp-out on the school grounds.
- Childcare at evening parent meetings.
- Montessori schools work hard to nurture every child's artistic and musical potential. Every student aged five and above receives instrumental instruction, participates in ensemble performances, and studies art. These programs have led to remarkable displays of talent. The school stages musical theater and ensemble performances during the year.
- Ideally, schools have a room on campus where parents can sit and read about Montessori or talk with other parents.
- They keep a pot of coffee and/or tea going for parents who drop in.
- The school phone is answered promptly with warmth.
- There is a suggestion box for parents, teachers, and students.
- They frequently ask families, teachers, and staff what they think.
- They hold informal discussions to brainstorm and explore new ideas.
- They defend your community against hostile or negative parents, children, and staff.
- They take the time to explain things fully.
- They publish an Annual Report on the state of the school.
- They hold school wide talent shows or art exhibits where students of all ages can showcase their talents or artwork.



A Montessori byline could be similar to this line from Yeats:

***“There are no strangers here.
Only friends you have yet to meet.”***

- Older students mentor younger ones in various areas, such as academics, arts, or sports.
- They make sure that no one ever feels threatened or blind-sided at a parent/teacher conference.
- Many schools have student-led conferences during which students guide their parents through their learning journey. This can be especially empowering for older students, giving them a chance to showcase their progress and achievements.
- They gather the children's work, stories, and art into portfolios to give to their families.
- They hold Parent Forums: open discussions in which parents explore an issue of broad interest among themselves.
- They create an atmosphere of safety, cleanliness, and timeless beauty on their campus.
- They celebrate cultural diversity within the school with festivals encouraging families to share their heritage



and learn about others while fostering a rich, inclusive community.

- They organize sports events or fun runs where families participate in activities or challenges.
- To add a fun twist to community engagements, some Montessori schools have introduced innovative events such as the "Are-You-Smarter-Than-a-Montessori-Kid?" contest. This light-hearted game challenges parents to answer questions that children learn in their Montessori classes, such as recognizing European flags or solving complex puzzles. These events not only provide entertainment but also offer parents a glimpse into the depth and breadth of their children's knowledge.
- They make a commitment as a school community to an ongoing program of self-study and school improvement in which parents, teachers, older students, and staff can get involved.
- They take the time as a community to develop and periodically review a "Blueprint of the School's Educational Philosophy and Core Values."
- Teachers call parents regularly just to share good news or to touch base.
- They make sure that new volunteers are carefully taught how to do the tasks that they've undertaken.
- They publish an attractive school newsletter on a regular basis that contains articles that parents want to read and pictures of children doing interesting things.
- They give each other lots of acknowledgement and a sense of pride.
- They send out press releases of any and all newsworthy information to the media.
- They create a special acknowledgment pin to recognize parents and teachers who have made an extraordinary contribution of service to the school.



- They design a colorful window decal with the name and logo of the school and give them to parents and teachers to put in the car's rear windows.
- They create a terrific school t-shirt and include at least one in the price of tuition and "give" it to every child.
- They develop a Montessori Speaker Series, inviting experts in Montessori education, child psychology, and related fields to speak to parents and local families.
- They host a panel of older students, alumni, and parents who share the positive impact Montessori education has had on their lives. This can be particularly inspiring for new families.
- They facilitate support groups for parents to discuss common challenges and share advice, particularly helpful for those adjusting to the Montessori system.
- They involve parents and families in community service projects organized by the school, reflecting the Montessori values of social responsibility and community engagement.
- They post a page on the school website to acknowledge the teachers, families, or special volunteers for their service to the school.

- They organize book clubs for parents, focusing on literature related to Montessori education and child development. Discussions can be facilitated by teachers or knowledgeable parents, fostering a deeper understanding of the Montessori philosophy.
- They encourage student-run cafés. Some provide a practical learning experience for students and a gathering spot for the community where parents, teachers, and students can interact informally, enhancing community ties.
- They share meals at various events, underscoring the importance of coming together and bonding over food. This tradition is essential for building strong, lasting relationships within the school community.

Montessori schools tend to be vibrant communities. Their unique traditions, commitment to arts and culture, and dedication to creating a warm and inclusive environment exemplify the best of Montessori education. ■



Tim Seldin is President of the Montessori Foundation and Chair of the International Montessori Council. His more than 40 years of experience in Montessori education includes 22 years as Headmaster of the Barrie School in Silver Spring, Maryland, his *alma mater* from toddler through high school graduation. Tim was Co-Founder and Director of the Institute for Advanced Montessori Studies and the Center for Guided Montessori Studies. He earned a B.A. in History and Philosophy from Georgetown University, an M.Ed. in Educational Administration and Supervision from The American University, and his Montessori certification from the American Montessori Society. Tim Seldin is the author of several books on Montessori Education, including *How to Raise An Amazing Child*, and *The World in the Palm of Her Hand*. Look for his new book, *Montessori for Every Family*, co-authored with Lorna McGrath.

EMBRACING CHANGE

Transitioning to a Traditional Middle School

by Cassi Mackey, M.Ed



Note from the Director: This article includes so many tips for helping children and adolescents in the transition from one school to another. It is packed with practical ways to be of support to them whether they are changing schools or levels within schools. Much of the material applies to all ages, but you will need to determine what is age appropriate for your child or adolescent's stage of development.

Change is a part of life. It is not always easy, but it speaks to the beautiful ebb and flow of our existence. When we trust the transitions, the changing seasons, and all the new roads we choose to take, we can fully celebrate our journey. The ability to gracefully embrace and receive change is a key to living a fulfilled, meaningful life and is a powerful part of our growth. If we can help our children embrace change, they will have the foundation to meet life with the resilience, optimism, fortitude, and joy that it demands.

Just as this age group is learning to cope with the emotional and physical turbulence of early adolescence, along comes the new challenge of transitioning from elementary to middle school; it also comes with new expectations, from academic to social. Changing schools from a Montessori school to a more traditional school or changing levels within a Montessori school is the perfect opportunity to teach about graceful transitions and embracing change.

All children manage change differently, but most Montessori students adapt to their new school environment fairly quickly, making new friends and experiencing success, within the definition of success understood in their new school. This phenomenon is possible because they have the advantage of growing up in Montessori. Montessori programs focus on helping children develop self-motivation, confidence, independence, problem-solving, and coping strategies for new situations, along with a strong sense of respect and responsibility. These skills, along with supportive parents and caregivers to help them embrace the change, will serve them well in any transition they make. What follows are suggestions to help make the school transition smoother for all.

FOLLOW MONTESSORI PRINCIPLES IN THE HOME

Following Montessori principles at home can be an impactful way of nurturing and maintaining skills and lessons that your tween learned from their experience in the Montessori school. Encouraging independence, love of learning,

curiosity, self-motivation, and order are fundamental to the Montessori approach and, if nurtured, will continue to serve your tween as they make this transition.

MODEL A POSITIVE ATTITUDE ABOUT CHANGE

Children are regularly learning how to be adaptable and flexible from their parents/caregivers. When children see you try new things, take risks, and handle change with grace, they are more likely to follow suit.

Talk to your child about change in a positive way. For example, you might say, “I am a bit nervous about starting a new job today, and it’s ok to be nervous. I am going to make myself feel better by listening to some good music. Even though I am nervous, I am also excited about meeting new people and making new friends.”

When your tweens are anxious, help them change the story they are telling themselves about what might happen. Encourage them to imagine all the great things that could happen instead of all the things that could go wrong. By changing the story and the images, anxiety can turn to excitement.

ACKNOWLEDGE THE UNCERTAINTY AND LOSS

Acknowledging the fear and anxiety regarding the change that both you as a parent/caregiver and your tween is experiencing makes it much easier to talk about and embrace the change together. This is a good opportunity to explain the differences between Montessori and traditional schools, emphasizing the positives of both school systems.

While we want to be positive about the change, change also means that there will be a loss of friends, teachers, familiar



OFFER YOUR TWEEN A SENSE OF AGENCY BY INVOLVING THEM IN MAKING CHOICES... IT CAN BE AS SIMPLE AS LETTING THEM SELECT A NEW BACKPACK.

routines, etc. Let your tween experience the sadness, and let them know they can speak to you about it or talk it over with friends that are experiencing the same thing.

PRACTICE MINDFULNESS

Practice mindfulness with your tween; it will help both of you to accept the present moment as it is, without judgment. This mindset can be useful when facing unexpected changes. After acknowledging your anxiety or fear and telling yourself that it's ok to feel this way at this moment, carry on in a way that purposefully isn't stuck in the negative mindset.

SHOW EMPATHY

Acknowledging your tween's emotions will help them feel seen and heard. For example, a parent/caregiver could say, "I understand that moving schools is a big fear of yours. There will be new things that you are not used to; I can see how not knowing what to expect can cause anxiety." Rephrasing the tween's emotions can help to increase their self-awareness and emotional intelligence, which will help them identify what they are feeling and can thereby talk about it.

ENGAGE IN OPEN COMMUNICATION

Talking and listening are key to helping your tween manage change. It is a valuable opportunity for you to sit and talk with your tween about what they think about this upcoming change, what is making them hesitant or nervous about this new opportunity, and what you can do together to make the process easier.

FIND THE ROOT OF ANXIETY AND FEAR

Ask questions to help guide your tween to what may be truly bothering them. For example, "What are you feeling

right now?" or "What feels scary to you about this?" or "What is the thing you think about most regarding this change?"

ENCOURAGE AN OPEN MIND TOWARDS CHANGE

Once you get a handle on what is causing them the most stress or fear, you can try to address it with your child ahead of time to help the change go smoothly. Start by asking them to reflect on what has helped them through other transitions they have had to make in their life and what they would add to that process to support this change. Change can feel overwhelming and scary to tweens because it often signals a loss of control. Offer your tween a sense of agency by involving them in making choices regarding this change, it can be as simple as letting them select a new backpack.

MAINTAIN ROUTINES YET ADD NEW ONES

If possible, maintain your family's normal routines. It will provide a sense of normalcy and security for your tween, since they will be experiencing new routines at school. You may also want to consider creating new routines for them to associate with this new phase of their life.

For example, you may decide to have family game nights on Thursdays. Get your tween involved in deciding on a new addition to the family schedule. Connecting as a family provides comfort for tweens who are navigating change, and these new activities can help.

BE PATIENT

"It will take the time it takes" for your tween to adjust to a new school. Don't assume either that they will have a hard time adjusting or that they will have an easy time adjusting.



PREPARE FOR LOGISTICAL, SOCIAL, AND ACADEMIC CHANGE

Researchers have found that tweens anticipating the move to middle school worry about these aspects of the change: the logistical, the social, and the academic.

LOGISTICAL

- Accompany your tween on a campus or new-environment tour and orientation. The better you understand the logistics of the school and the program, the more you can support your tween. Invite their friends who are also making the transition.
- Ask for a copy of your tween's schedule and mark the locations and times of their classes on the school map. Ask for the length of the break between classes. Walk the route between classes with them. Time it out with

Be patient and let your child know you are there for them. Reassure them that they are going to have a great school year, and, before they know it, they'll no longer feel like the new kid.

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your tween, so they can see how long it takes to walk from class to class.

- If you have an opportunity, sign your tween up for any summer programs that may be offered by the school for incoming students. Not only will your tween get to know the campus, but they also will have the opportunity to make some friends in a much more relaxed atmosphere.
- Review the rules and requirements in the student handbook. Ask the school staff for any clarification or questions you may have before the beginning of school.
- If the school has lockers, make sure they know how to open the lock. Or, buy your tween a lock with time to practice opening and closing it.

SOCIAL

- Talk to your tweens often and openly about friendship. Equip them with the information and knowledge to make good friendship choices. Talk about how they should treat other people and how they should allow other people to treat them. Encourage them to stay away from gossip and drama. Help them learn how to navigate conflict and how to resolve disagreement. Remind them to be kind and inclusive.



- Emphasize the importance of being who they are. Remind them that it is more important to be yourself than to fit in. Encourage them to spend time with people they like and with whom they are comfortable, but to also look for less obvious connections and be open. Talk about the importance of not compromising their values to gain friends.
- Support your tween's personal interests. Suggest your tween join sports teams, school clubs, or extracurricular activities.
- Offer them opportunities to spend time with any new friends they have made.
- If they are experiencing loneliness, you could arrange a get together with old friends.
- Encourage your tweens to join conversations or activities. You can role play how to join without interrupting or how to add something interesting or relevant to the conversation in progress.
- Let them see your own positive supportive joyful friendships.
- Get to know the tweens that your tween spends time with, and, if possible, their parents or caregivers.
- Discuss how their bodies are (or will be) changing and the importance of self-care and good hygiene.

ACADEMIC

- Meet with your tween to discuss academic expectations in the new school and at a new level and how the family is going to support them.
- If you have concerns about your child's academic needs, meet with the middle school's academic team in the spring (before they begin school) to discuss your concerns.

- Reach out to the teachers to introduce yourself and offer any support. You can give teachers some information about your child regarding their strengths and where they experience challenges. This introduction is a good time to give teachers strategies that have been successful specifically for your child.
- Find out if there is a homework hotline or if there is a tutor service.
- Help your tween with their time management and organizational skills. Work together on a schedule that allows for study time, social time, chore time, etc. Show your tween how to organize binders, set up assignment calendars, and use an academic planner.
- Receiving grades may be new for a Montessori student. Try not to react either way to the grades. Making sure your tween is happy and navigating the expectations of the new system is the most important factor in the first couple of months.
- Stay connected to your tween's schoolwork by lending support when needed. Know due dates for homework, projects, or other tasks. Periodically check to see if your tween is getting assignments done, yet continue to build independence.
- This should not be a problem for a former Montessori student, but encourage your tween to be their own advocate by discussing problems and solutions with their teachers on their own. Of course, you will be ready to support them if need be.
- If your tween is struggling, meet with the academic team sooner than later.
- Model the behavior you want to encourage in your tween. Are you arriving at places on time? Are you keeping appointments? Do you use a calendar to keep your schedule?

As your child crosses this bridge on the path towards a new school experience, they don't disappear, they transform, and you get to witness this marvelous show of becoming. Change will be their constant ally, leading them through unexplored places and presenting opportunities for growth and self-discovery. Their willingness to adapt and evolve will be essential in shaping who they become. If they learn to embrace the change, the challenges, the unpredictability, and the disconcertment, they will truly uncover the unlimited potential that lies within them.

Teach them how to embrace change, and watch them emerge... stronger, peaceful, and wiser. ■



Cassi Mackey, M.Ed. is passionate about helping communities create identity-safe spaces where people are encouraged to make changes to improve relationships. Cassi has witnessed the transformational power of communities that engage in...Courageous Conversation, Collaborative Coaching, and Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, Justice, and belonging practices. It is a promise of more meaningful relationships, greater depth of experience, and a broader, more compassionate view of oneself and the world. These practices are essential in order to serve our children and the future of humanity.

Cassi has been in the Montessori field for 30 years as a teacher and school leader. She is currently an American Montessori Society (AMS) School Accreditation Commissioner, Instructional Guide for CGMS Leadership Certification and a trainer for the AMI Administrator certification course. She is certified as an Association Montessori Internationale (AMI) School Administrator and has completed the AMS Anti-bias Anti-racist certification course. She consults with and provides advice to Montessori communities that are intent on generating positive and lasting change.

The Progression of Left to Right in Montessori Language Development

by Aradhna Dhawan



The Montessori Method, developed by Dr. Maria Montessori, is renowned for its child-centered approach to education. Within the Montessori classroom, language development plays a crucial role in nurturing a child's ability to communicate effectively. While the Montessori Method itself is adaptable to various writing systems and cultural contexts, it often incorporates a left-to-right progression in language activities and materials. This article explores the reasons behind the left-to-right progression in Montessori language development, provides examples of materials used in the classroom, and highlights research insights on this topic.

The Importance of Left-to-Right Progression: The left-to-right progression is a convention followed in many languages for reading and writing. Introducing children to language and literacy skills in a manner that aligns with this convention can facilitate their understanding of written texts and prepare them for independent reading and writing. By incorporating left-to-right progression in

language activities, Montessori educators create an environment that not only supports language development but also prepares children for successful literacy experiences beyond the classroom. The consistent use of this convention helps children build essential cognitive and linguistic skills, fostering their ability to read, write, and engage with written language effectively.

Examples of Materials and Activities in Montessori Language Development

Sandpaper Letters: Sandpaper Letters are tactile materials with textured letters mounted on wooden boards. Children trace the shape of each letter with their fingers while simultaneously associating the sound with the symbol. These letters are typically arranged from left to right, reinforcing the directionality of writing.

Moveable Alphabet: The Moveable Alphabet is a set of individual letters, often made of wood or plastic, that children can manipulate to form words. Children choose letters and arrange them from left to right to represent the sounds they hear in words. This activity aligns with the left-to-right progression of writing in many languages.

Reading Books: Montessori classrooms include a variety of books at different reading levels. As children progress in their reading abilities, they are encouraged to read from left to right, following the conventional reading direction. Teachers provide guidance and support as children navigate the pages and sentences.

Research Insights: While specific research articles linking Montessori materials with left-to-right progression in language development are limited, studies have highlighted

the effectiveness of the Montessori method in enhancing early literacy skills. Research by Lillard and Else-Quest (2006) found that children in Montessori programs showed higher levels of phonological awareness, letter recognition, and early reading skills compared to non-Montessori peers. Furthermore, studies by Rathunde and Csikszentmihalyi (2005) and Dohrmann et al. (2007) indicated that Montessori education fosters independent reading and writing skills, with children developing a sense of confidence and engagement in their language abilities. Introducing children to language and literacy skills in a manner that reflects this convention has several important benefits: alignment with reading and writing conventions; cognitive organization; structure preparation for independent reading; and writing consistency and familiarity.



Overall, the left-to-right progression in Montessori language development aligns with the conventions followed in many languages, providing children with a solid foundation for future reading and writing skills. By understanding and practicing this natural flow of language, children are equipped with the tools to navigate and comprehend the written world around them. ■

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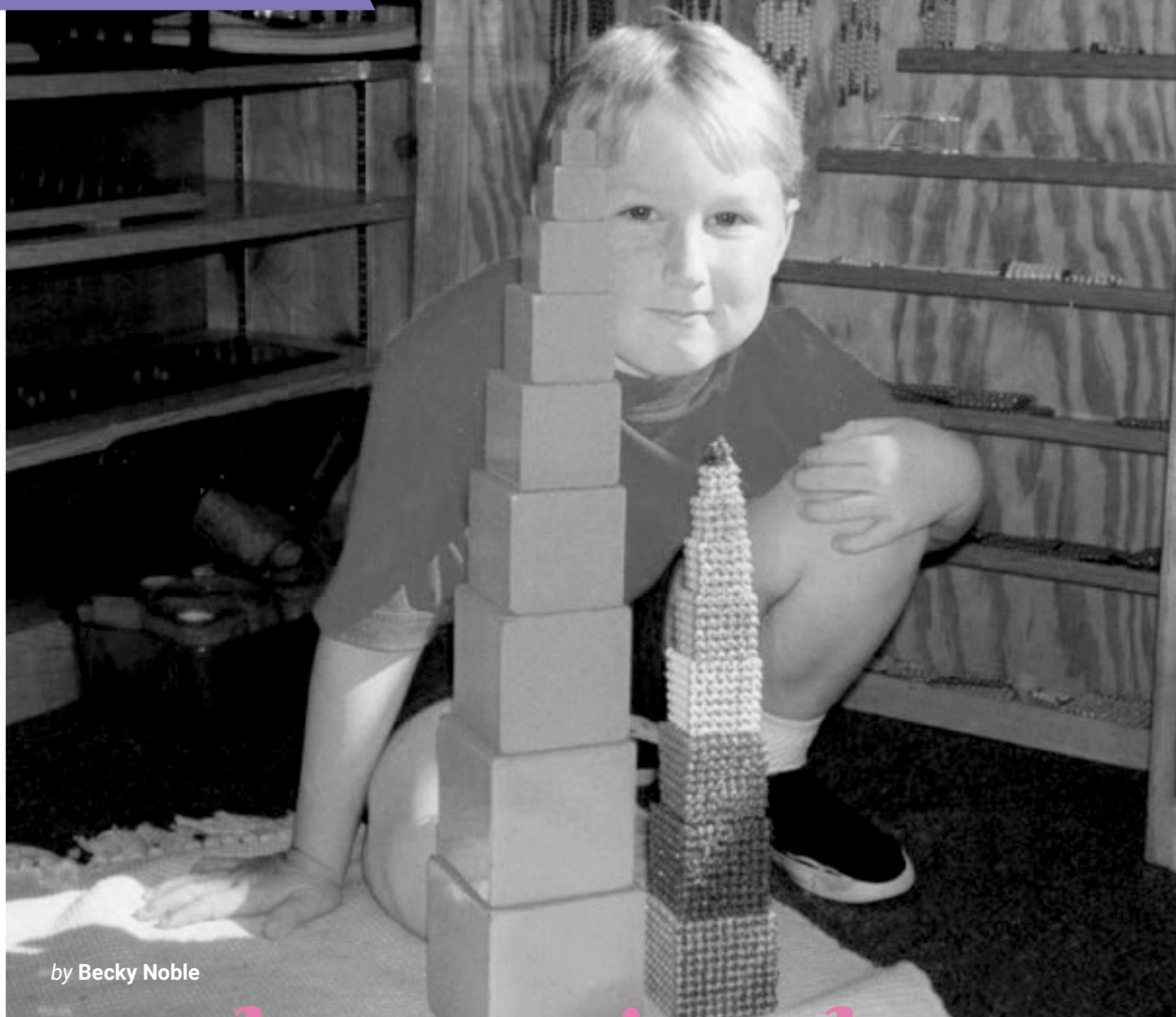
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Conclusion: While the Montessori Method itself is adaptable to different writing systems and languages, it often incorporates a left-to-right progression in language development activities and materials. The use of materials, such as Sandpaper Letters, Moveable Alphabets, and reading books, supports the natural progression of reading and writing skills in many cultures. While further research specifically linking Montessori materials to left-to-right progression is limited (as mentioned earlier in this article), existing studies demonstrate the effectiveness of the Montessori Method in promoting early literacy skills and independent language exploration in children.



Aradhna Dhawan is a certified Montessori Educator 3-6. Eager to expand her knowledge, refine her skills, and create a prepared environment that fosters independence, critical thinking, and a love for learning. Through this pursuit, Aradhna is currently pursuing AMI Elementary Diploma 6-12 and AMI School Leadership Certificate.



by Becky Noble

a determined mom

I have been a strong supporter of Montessori education since before Ben was born, having read several of Maria Montessori's books and applied those methods when working with my employer's young children.

When it was time for Ben's dad and me to decide on a kindergarten for Ben, we considered a few options. Ben's dad had been in public school throughout his education and felt that, if it was good enough for him, it was good enough for Ben. He was, however, willing to look at private schools as well. I recall visiting at least three schools, including the

public elementary school closest to our home, a Christian School, and Countryside/NewGate Montessori.

Even though I expected lower standards at the public school, I was floored when the teacher told us that not every student was expected to know the whole alphabet by the end of the kindergarten year. Ben and his preschool classmates all knew the alphabet and had started reading by that time. Although the education level at the Christian School seemed to be up to my expectations, the classrooms were noisy and cluttered.

When we visited Countryside/NewGate, I knew that was where Ben would flourish. The quiet, orderly classrooms provided an ideal place for a young child to learn. I appreciated the respect with which each student was treated, and the way conflicts were resolved. I found the three-year age span in the classrooms to be an excellent way for a student to experience being a beginner, learning from the older students, and to work his/her way up to being a leader among the students, helping the younger ones. I was also happy to hear that each student could progress at his/her own pace, not being held back to the level of the lowest common denominator.

Yes, there were some sacrifices made to have Ben attend Montessori school all the way through high school. Ben's dad and I separated two months after Ben began Montessori school. I faced all the challenges that single parents face: reworking my schedule to accommodate Ben's needs; trying to make ends meet; figuring out the financial aspect; etc. It was a very difficult time, but I was determined to provide Ben with what I considered to be his best educational opportunity. Looking back on it now, that was one of the most valuable things that I have gone through. I learned to be resourceful and to stand by my principles when it came to raising Ben.

Ben's dad and I contributed to a portion of the tuition, but the bulk of it was on my shoulders. Even though it was a stretch to pay each month, I was not willing to lower my standards and deny Ben the opportunities he had at Countryside/New Gate School. The school helped with a generous contribution in the form of a scholarship. I believe paying at least a portion of the tuition gave me a bigger stake in my child's education and I tended to be even more involved in it. When my new partner, Michael, came into our family full-time, he was active in projects and events at the school as he saw and supported the value of the education that Ben was getting. Ben graduated from NewGate School in 2005.

Now that Ben is grown, married, and the father of two beautiful girls, Michael and I support Ben and Kara's

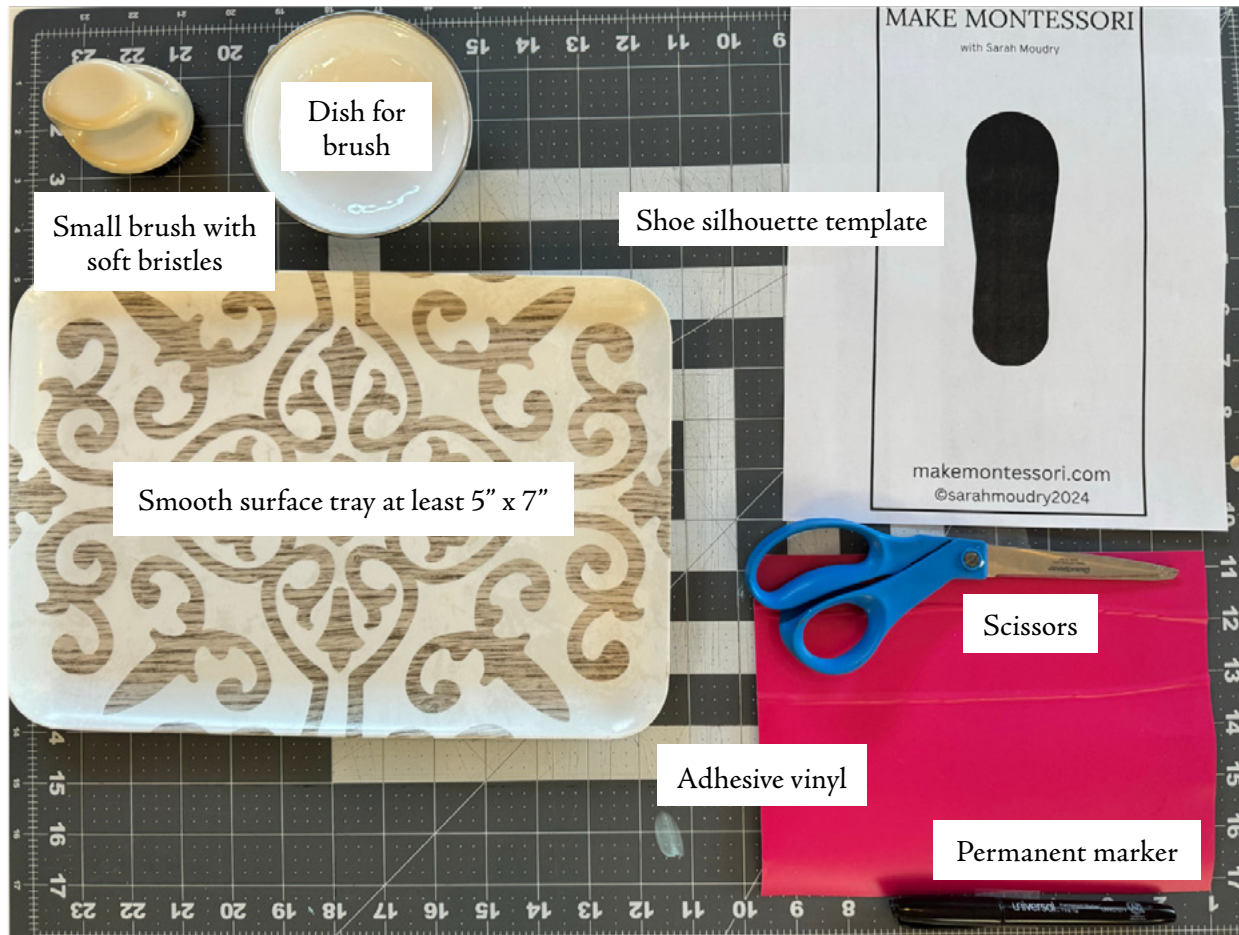
choice to enroll Aurora and Felicity in a good Montessori school. I'm delighted that both girls are doing so well in that environment. ■



Becky Noble (shown above) grew up in rural Pennsylvania, traveling around the country with her family every summer. For four years after graduation, she sailed the European coast and Caribbean, overseeing the galleys and teaching math and world history aboard the schooners of the Flint School. She transferred to their Sarasota, Florida office to help build ActionQuest travel adventure and Lifeworks community service programs that would eventually become Global Expeditions. She recently relocated to Franklin, Tennessee to be close to Ben and his family. When not spending time with her granddaughters, Becky now runs an online business and is a watercolor artist who enjoys sharing her knowledge with young people.

SHOE CLEANING

by Sarah Moudry



Purpose

- Develop independence in care of self
- Strengthening and refinement of movements of the hands

Age

- 16 months and up

Young children enjoy learning to care for themselves and their environment. Dr. Montessori described these activities as Practical Life activities and you will find them in all Montessori classrooms from birth through high school.

When children learn to take care of themselves and their environment, they experience inner pride and confidence. This supports their need to do for themselves independently and serves their intellectual, physical, and language development.

Learning to clean shoes is a fun activity for young children. As a parent, you can introduce this activity and keep it available to your child in a space that makes sense: near your entry; on a cleaning supply shelf; or even in your broom closet. Once you show your child how to use this activity, keep the set intact (don't let the pieces migrate around the house), remind your child of the true purpose if they use the tools for other activities, and remove the activity if your child is not able to use it safely.

Instructions

1. Trace the shoe silhouette template on the adhesive vinyl with the marker.



2. Cut out the Shoe silhouette and set aside.



3. Wipe the tray surface with a clean dry towel.

4. Remove the backing of the cut shoe shape.



5. Place the shoe shape in the center of the tray so that the length of the shoe shape is parallel with the handle sides of the tray.



6. Press the shoe shape with your hands and smooth out any bubbles.

7. Place the brush dish on the upper left side of the tray.



8. Place the brush in the brush dish.

Lesson

1. As with all Practical Life activities, show your child the tools you will need, what they are called, and how to hold them.

2. Remind your child that you will show them how to do the activity and then they will have a turn.
3. To clean shoes, place one shoe on the shoe shape and one shoe to the left of you on the floor.
4. Place one hand in the shoe, and hold the brush with the other.
5. Gently brush the shoe.
6. Turn the shoe side to side so your child can see that you are looking for dirt.
7. Place the brush back in the dish.
8. Place the shoe next to the one on the floor.
9. Pick up the other shoe and place it on the tray.
10. Invite your child to have a turn!

When your child is done, they can see what other shoes are around the house to clean. This activity combined with the hunt of finding shoes can make this activity last a long time. Once your child understands the activity, you can say things like..."I think I remember a pair of brown shoes in your dad's closet..." By doing this you are supporting your child's awareness of their environment, need to engage socially and genuinely, as well as your child's language development. Try using different adjectives to describe shoes they may find.

Resources



Scan for Shoe
Silhouette Template



Scan for Toys and
Tools Tutorial

OFF TO THE Ballet

by Margot Garfield-Anderson



One of my fondest memories I've shared with my granddaughter, Blakely, was talking about the time we went to the ballet together when she was five years old. We had watched the *Nutcracker* numerous times before we finally actually went to see a live performance. I bought her a special dress to wear, we got all fancied up and ready, and off we went.

Everyone sitting around us looked at her in wonderment as she wore a very excited expression on her face. The music began and the ballet started to unfold. She leaned in next to me and said, "Grammie, that's not how Clara should be doing that dance." It seems that she had memorized the version we had watched, and I had neglected to let her know that every dance troop's choreographer interprets the dance parts a little bit differently. She still enjoyed the show and every time I stole a glance over at her I could see total rapture on her face.

Her interests have long ago steered away from watching the *Nutcracker*. She is now almost fourteen and an avid

soccer player. However, I just recently asked if she remembered that night. "Grammie," she said, "how could I ever forget it." I hope she shares a similar experience with her grandchildren if the time comes.

Creating lasting memories and sharing your passions with your grandchildren creates bonds that can't be undone, so invest the time in them and with them. The payoff is huge and lasting. ■



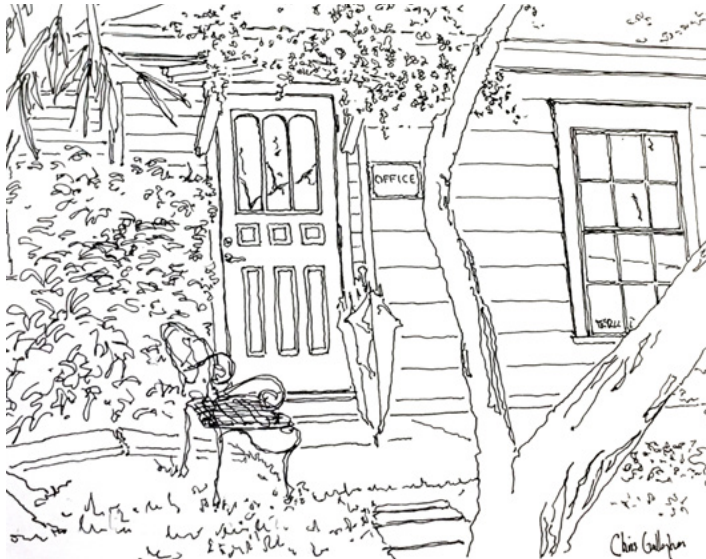
Margot Garfield-Anderson is the retired Montessori Foundation Project Manager and International Montessori Council Membership Director. She continues to be involved in the organization as an IMC Board member and serves as a reader of documents for schools going through the IMC accreditation process. She still enjoys sharing her grandparenting experiences with *Tomorrow's Child* subscribers. She also volunteers for many other nonprofits and organizations in Sarasota, Florida.

HIGHLIGHTING MEMBER SCHOOLS

Countryside/NewGate School, Sarasota, FL

CELEBRATING 40 YEARS (1984-2024)

by Montessori Foundation Staff


Drawing of School

In the early 1980s Kitty Williams (now Bravo) and her former husband, Farmer Steve Williams, lived on 5 acres of land with their two young daughters in their small, old-Florida home on Ashton Road in Sarasota, FL. Farmer Steve dreamed of an organic farm, while Kitty dreamed of a Montessori school; both dreamed of making the world a better place. They established Countryside Montessori School, in January of 1984, on a side porch of their home, with just five children, and Steve farmed the land. During that winter and spring, the garage was remodeled, and they applied to the zoning department for permission to officially have a school on the property. In August of 1984, the garage classroom opened with about twenty children: ages 2 years 11 months to 6 years old. By the fall of 1985, the porch had been enclosed and a second Primary classroom was opened, bringing the total enrollment to about forty students.

By 1987, the school expanded to include an Elementary program with just a few first graders continuing from the



Primary class. A Toddler classroom was established in a small building on the roadside that had been Farmer Steve's produce store. Within a year, the Elementary class expanded to first through third grades with Primary moving to the small classroom that was once the produce store.

Countryside kept growing, and in 1989 they built a spacious classroom with natural light for the expanding Elementary class. Now the school had three Primary classes, one Lower Elementary class, and a group of very enthusiastic, committed parents.

During the 1990s, the dream kept growing and the Williams restructured the school as a non-profit with the hope that they could continue through the high school years. With the help of some parents, they acquired the portable buildings, which they remodeled to expand the Elementary program. By the fall of 1993, they had three Primary classrooms, two Lower Elementary classrooms, and one Upper Elementary classroom.

On the school's 10th Anniversary, after a decade of growth and dreams, Kitty and Steve, along with a dedicated group of families and staff, began to partner with the Montessori Foundation and became the Foundation's "lab school." So many things were accomplished during the 90s. They changed the school's name to NewGate School (gate being an acronym for "global awareness through education"). After changing the name to NewGate School, they purchased one hundred acres of land for future development

of a second campus, and added a Toddler class, another Upper Elementary class, and a 7th & 8th Year class (Middle School) at Ashton.

The dream wasn't done yet! In the 2000s, NewGate opened its second campus on Clark Road and added the high school. In their 20th Anniversary year (2004) two beautiful things happened. First, a peace pole was erected in a lovely place in the center of the Ashton Road Campus in honor of Kitty's work in Montessori for world peace. Second, NewGate had its first high school graduate! Big dreams were accomplished, and big challenges present-



Drawing of School

virtual campus for Secondary students from around the US and the world). We serve children and adolescents from Toddlers through High School.

NewGate is proud to be the “lab school” of the Montessori Foundation (MF). Being the lab school of the Foundation means trying new ideas based on our tried-and-true Montessori principles. We have spent a lot of time developing models and systems for other schools to use as they grow and expand organizing new programs to enhance the already existing Montessori curriculum; creating a model for Montessori Secondary schools; sponsoring teacher training programs; and cultivating a community of respectful adults who mentor and guide children and adolescents by doing their best to live out the principles of peace. ■



Written by **Lorna McGrath**, NewGate Board member, with the help of **Kitty Bravo**, Founder of the School, and **Lauren Speed**, 'long-time member of the NewGate faculty and administrative team.



ed themselves. However, faith and determination did not wane and NewGate pushed forward with renewed assistance from the Montessori Foundation. When the Clark Road Campus closed, all students returned to the original campus on Ashton Road.

By the time the 30th Anniversary came around the school's recovery was well underway, and in 2016, a new campus for the Secondary students was purchased in Lakewood Ranch. Now, in 2024, NewGate's 40th Anniversary year, we have three campuses: the Ashton Road Campus; the Lakewood Ranch Campus; and the Global Campus (a

Concentration and Focus

by Cathie Perolman

DEAR CATHIE—

WE THINK IT IS TIME FOR OUR CHILD TO EXPERIENCE LEARNING OPPORTUNITIES IN ADDITION TO MONTESSORI SCHOOL. WE THINK HE IS READY FOR SOME EXTRACURRICULAR ACTIVITIES. WHILE WE KNOW THAT IT IS POSSIBLE TO BE OVERSCHEDULED, WE DO WANT OUR CHILD TO TAKE ADVANTAGE OF ALL THAT OUR AMAZING COMMUNITY HAS TO OFFER. HOW DO WE BALANCE THIS?

— A SERIOUS PARENT

Dear Parents,

You are right on target, and we applaud your conscientious approach to this complicated subject. The rule of thumb is to follow your child interests and seek to broaden their experiences until they are old enough to have found their passion. The purpose of extracurricular activities for young children is to try new things, develop new skills, and have opportunities to take direction from another adult besides parents and teachers at school.

We recommend that young children experience extracurriculars in small segments for the purpose of just trying them out. These are usually offered in areas such as sports, dance, drama, art, etc. Seek classes that are in short sections such as 8 weeks or a week-long summer program. The purpose of these of classes is to expose children to the activity or skill. These short introductions help parent and child determine interest, without overtaxing the child or family's resources. These classes focus on the basics. It may be possible to engage your child in a summer camp that encompasses a number of different sports or types of dance at a single location. From there it is possible to decide where to focus

your child and family's resources in the years ahead.

Many towns have recreation sports leagues as well as travel leagues that require children to try out for a place on the team. However, your child may enjoy being a part of the experience at any level. Additionally, sometimes activities are offered as single day camps during days off from school. These may include computer skills, 3-D printing, cooking classes, etc. These one-day activities can help you widen a child's awareness of the myriad of activities available to pursue.

As children mature, they begin to narrow their focus and gravitate toward some extracurricular activities more than others. Many begin to show an affinity for a particular activity such as scouting, a specific

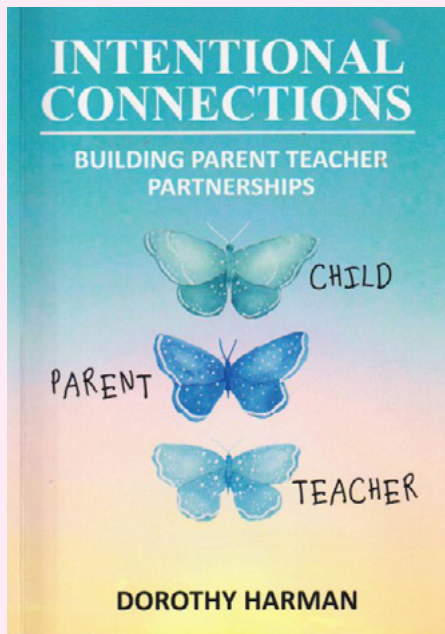
sport, a type of musical instrument, a dance class, etc. Now is the time to zone into one (or a few) of these areas and begin to focus your child's after school time. You may eventually decide that private music or dance classes are for your child. Maybe your child is committed to soccer and is attending practice twice a week and playing a game once a week as well. Each of these comes with a time and financial commitment on your part, and that needs to be figured into the equation. Be sure to involve your child in the decision and not simply decide for them.

As you are making these decisions, remember to program in some free time for your child to have time outdoors to play, create, and spend unstructured time with friends. This is an important part of your child's development as well. ■



Cathie Perolman is a reading specialist, Elementary educator, author, consultant, and creator of educational materials. For over three decades, she has dedicated her energies to improving reading for all youngsters.

She is the author of *Practical Special Needs for the Montessori Method: A Handbook for 3-6 Teachers and Homeschoolers* (available through montessori.org). She is a regular contributor to *Tomorrow's Child* and *Montessori Leadership* magazines. Cathie holds a BS in Early Childhood Education and a MEd in Elementary Education, with a concentration in reading. She is credentialed as a Montessori teacher. Check out her new downloadable materials on her website cathieperolman.com.



Intentional Connections: Building Parent Teacher Partnerships

Written by Dorothy Harman

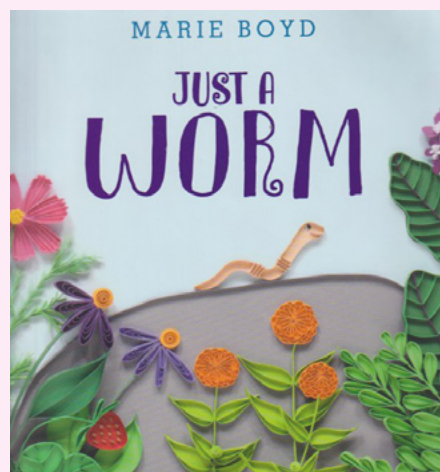
Parents, this is a book to put at the top of your “must read” list! It’s so user friendly and packed with such important information for all of us: parents, teachers, caregivers, and extended family. When I was halfway through it, I couldn’t put it down. My grandson is in Montessori school, and I wanted to send a copy to his parents immediately!

Dorothy Harman has so much wisdom to share and inspiration to offer about parent-teacher relationships, keeping the child’s best interests as the common goal. She has created a book that has only 39 pages, and it is formatted in such a way that you can read whatever topic is of interest to you or is needed for your child. AND, there is a section within almost all the topics called “An Idea for Consideration,” where you can

write notes. This section includes the idea, your reflections, your next steps, and discussion with the child’s teacher. It is such a great tool for gathering your thoughts.

You can purchase it through Montessori Services:

www.montessoriservices.com/building-parent-teacher-partnerships

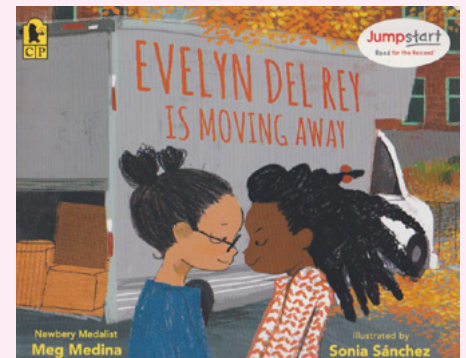


JUST A WORM

Written & illustrated by Marie Boyd

This book is illustrated using quill art techniques except for the worm (pen and ink) and the blue sky (digital). Its eye-catching colors and designs are quite beautiful. The author gives readers a lesson in quill art at the end of the book. The story itself is about the worm affirming that it is more than ‘just a worm.’ Along the way, the worm discovers how other garden insects contribute to the garden world. If you look closely, you’ll find the creature coming up on the next page. Although the story is wonderful for children from 3 to 7 years old, the quill art takes quite

a bit of fine-motor control. It may be frustrating for children 3, 4, and possibly 5 years old, while 6 and above may really get into making quill art.

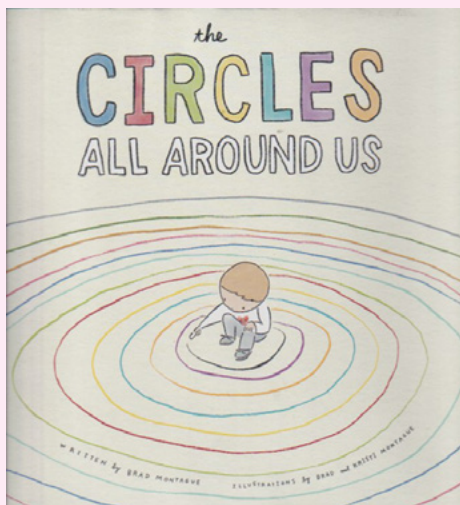


Evelyn Del Rey Is Moving Away

Written by Meg Medina

Illustrated by Sonia Sánchez

Touching. Meg Medina captures in a lovely way the feelings friends often have when they become physically distant from each other, as in a move to another town or city and the changes that occur in their relationship. The illustrations are vivid and quite realistic. They are reminiscent of Ezra Jack Keats’ style. The words come alive through these images. Jumpstart and Read for the Record are two organizations whose purposes are to help reduce the cycle of poverty through providing high quality books and reading. They have provided ideas for adults to enrich the reading experience with children through notes about how to interact with your young reader. Children 4 to 8 years old enjoy exploring the subject of friendships and how life circumstances can change relationships.

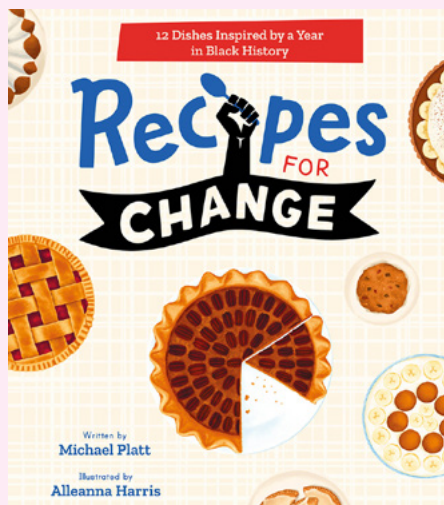


THE CIRCLES ALL AROUND US

Written by Brad Montague

Illustrated by Brad & Kristi Montague

This is a delightful story for children 3 to 7 years old, using ever enlarging circles to illustrate how we broaden our number and kinds of relationships among our human contacts and our world. It starts with a small child who draws a circle around himself that is only large enough for him. It shows the reader how small our scope is when we are infants. In fact, in infancy, humans really don't know that there is anyone else except themselves. Gradually they begin to realize that there are others around them. And so, the circle becomes larger to include immediate family and primary caregivers. I'll let you read this book to find out how far the author goes in expanding the circles. I will be a spoiler, though, and tell you the ending because it is so important. "...remember the first circle started with just the love you hold inside."



Recipes for Change

Written by Michael Platt

Illustrated by Alleanna Harris

Reviewed by Cheryl Allen

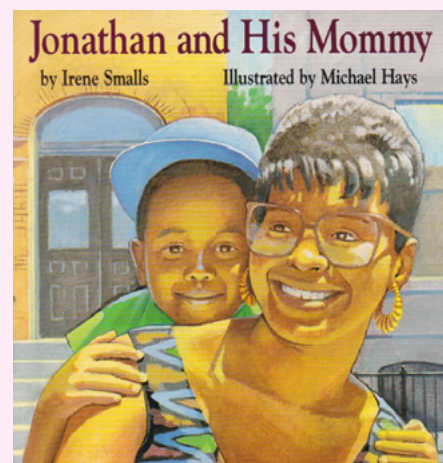
This book brings together so many interesting types of books. It is a cookbook, with stories from history and biographies. Each month of this book about Black history depicts an act of resistance and a recipe that is connected to the event. At the back of the book are short biographies of the leaders in the book.

Some of this information may be new to you, and some of it may present a slightly different angle of a piece of history. We may feel we know the leaders of the Montgomery Bus Boycott. In the December entry, you will learn about Georgia Gilmore and how she used her baking skills to help raise money for transportation for people who boycotted the bus system for more than a year. You can make her pound cake.

The recipes are easy to follow, and most need patience and possible adult

guidance. While waiting for any of the recipes to be ready to eat, the stories can be read, and the detailed illustrations admired. In addition to the biographies in the back, there is a glossary and additional book suggestions.

This book is suggested for ages 8-12. It could be enjoyed by younger children, although they may need more assistance to make the recipes.



Jonathan and His Mommy

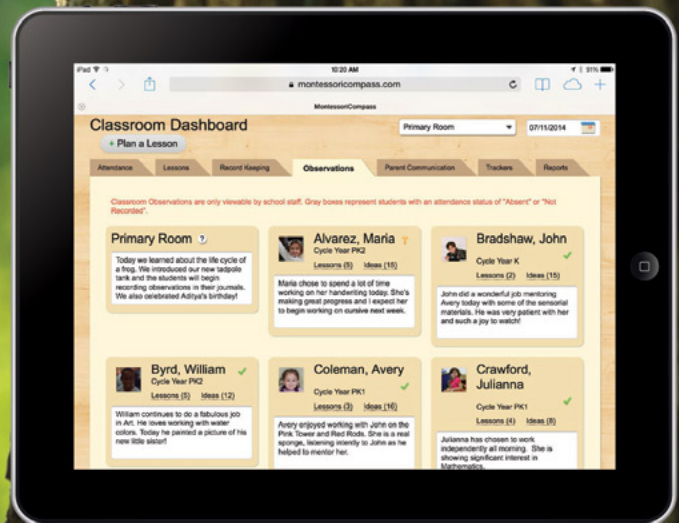
Written by Irene Smalls

Illustrated by Michael Hays

Jonathan loves to take walks with his mom. They enjoy each other's company and find all kinds of fun ways to move and to use their voices as they go through their city neighborhood. This time I won't spoil the surprises you'll find as you read this charming book. Children 3 to 7 will find this an interesting story and may want to try out some of the moves that Jonathan and his mother make together.

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